

surplus buttons, and it's one of the fastest ways for a cardigan to become useless.

5. Wash in cold water

People who wash their clothing in cold water will notice a drop in their energy bills very quickly. In addition, many fabrics (especially nylon and elastics) hold up better when subjected to less heat. Cold-water detergents are designed to remove dirt without the help of hot water, but even normal detergent will work well. Also, even though I try my hardest to be a stickler for the environment, a good capful of bleach will do amazing things for your whites—it's almost like having new clothing.

6. Wash inside out

Clothes with texture (jeans) or designs and adornments can last longer if washed inside out. With jeans, you'll find that holes around the knees where the fabric is worn thinner appear less quickly (unless you wanted the holes). You'll see less cracks and fading on your T-shirts, too.

7. Obey the laws of color

At the end of a long day, with loads and loads of laundry facing you, it

can be tempting to just throw the reds in with the blues, but try to keep like colors washed with like colors. Reds and blues fade easily, and everyone knows how one red sock can turn a whole load of whites a light shade of rose. Try your best to keep dissimilar colors apart in the laundry.

8. Zip up before washing

Unzipped zipper edges on pants and hoodies are often very rough, and if left unzipped during the washing and drying cycles, they'll chew up the rest of your clothing in no time! Make sure that all zippers are zipped to the top before tossing them in the wash. And while you're at it, fasten the bras, too, to prevent hooks from catching on delicate knits or sweaters.

9. Be gentle with underwear

Don't tumble-dry your over-the-shoulder-boulder-holders. Bras and underwear made of fabrics and fabric blends (especially nylon) besides cotton don't do well in the heat of a dryer. Hang or drape them to air-dry instead. And those little mesh bags that your mother used to nag you to use when washing delicate brassieres? They really do help to keep bra straps from wrapping around other clothing while in the wash.